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Rick Margitza

Saxophonist, composer, and jazz educator Rick Margitza has enjoyed an active career as a solo artist and sideman. He currently is a professor of arranging and harmony at the International Music Educators of Paris, and is the author of 365 Days of Practice.

Rick was interviewed via Zoom on November 22, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and we are going across the pond today, which technology-wise is pretty amazing. I'm speaking with Rick Margitza who is in Paris, is that correct?

RM: Yes, nice to be here.

MR: Nice to be talking to you, and congratulations on your career so far.

RM: Oh thank you. I appreciate it.

MR: I have a little anecdote I'll start with. This goes back a number of years. I was on the way home from a gig and listening to an all-night jazz radio station. I don't remember where it came from but this song came on — excuse my vocalizing — [scats].

RM: Nice voice.

MR: How about the rendition, do you recognize it?

RM: Yes it's from my first record, actually the first track, it's called "Widow's Walk."

MR: Yes. I was drawn into that, even actually before you came in with the melody with that sequence of chords, the arpeggiated — so I'd like to start with asking about that and in the larger sense your composing efforts. Do you recall the process of writing that song, and I hope when we're done that people watch this and they'll go listen to it because it's just gorgeous.

RM: Thank you. Yes I do, because certain songs come out really quickly and others take a while to work through and for whatever reason it just happens like that and one is not necessarily better than the other but "Widow's Walk" literally came out in about a half an hour. It's one of those that came really quickly. And you know when I first started composing a lot of it was at the piano so I remember just finding that ostinato at the beginning and trying it over different roots. Because it's the kind of thing that fits over different roots which makes it a different mode or a different chord. So once I found the bass line that basically kind of takes you through the song under the ostinato I kind of had the shell of the song first and then kind of improvised the melody over the form of the song.

MR: You improvised the melody?

RM: Well not complet — I mean I kind of came up with this little descending line and then I tinkered with it. So when I improvised it it wasn't in its final form but I just kind of came up with that melody as a result of hearing the ostinato in the chords. And I mean these days there's a — I think it's from Pat Metheny, he said, "Everybody has about seven or eight tunes in them and they keep writing different versions of that same tune." So I'm getting to that point where I'm repeating myself, or I feel like I'm repeating myself so I'm forcing myself to compose in different ways so I'm trying to not start with the piano anymore. Since my piano playing is somewhat limited I tend to move in the same harmonic worlds or the same kind of things that feel good under my hands. So now I'm trying to maybe just find a melody on the saxophone first or maybe find a drum beat or some type of groove [phone rings] sorry.

MR: Like I can totally relate to that. Because I usually start at the piano myself and like I'm not a fantastic piano player so I do find that I'm trying to put my hands down in different ways. Like, and you mentioned bass notes, like instead of thinking before your hands hit, okay I'm going to do some E flat thing, like just put your hands down and see what happens.

RM: Yes exactly. Just forcing myself just to come from different places and that's actually kind of been fruitful. I found a couple of — not full songs yet — but things that feel different. And it might also be something — I'll be watching a movie or a TV show and just hear a groove that wouldn't be something that I would normally start with and you just kind of do a little bit of — I don't know whose quote this is but they say, "In literature it's plagiarism but in music it's influence."

MR: I think I can remember this — Pepper Adams — Jerry Dodgion told me this story of Pepper Adams, they were in front of a whole group of students and you know they were talking about influences and so forth, and Pepper said, "If you take from one person it's plagiarism, if you take from everybody it's research."

RM: That's a good one. That's really good.

MR: Do you ever get an idea in your head, either from the piano or sax, and then go for a walk and find that you're working out possibilities in your head?

RM: Yes. Actually I have —I shouldn't say developed the ability over the years, it's just something that has happened is, even without, even like aside from composing is that I will practice in my head. There was recently an interesting little — I think it was one of those things called profiles in *DownBeat* where it wasn't a full blown article about Jerry Bergonzi — he said sometimes he'll just go and sit down or lay down on the couch and practice in his head for an hour. And so I've kind of — you know when you're waiting at the airport and you find yourself in these situations where you have time to kill I actually have kind of been over the years trying to utilize that time by taking an idea or a motive

and going through all the keys or a certain song and practicing it in different keys in my head, and just kind of imagining the sound and trying to feel the vibrations. And it actually is something that I've actually — I work with my students on doing. So I think that's actually a very beneficial thing to do. And then to answer your first question yes, I do sometimes will go for a walk and work through something that might be part of a song, not a whole song. And then come back and try to get it down on paper and then work it through. There's a Schoenberg book — a couple of his — one of them is called *Style and Idea* and it's a book, a collection of his essays and articles and commentaries and criticisms. It's like genius. Just so many amazing, really interesting things. And he composed away from the piano whereas Stravinsky composed everything at the piano supposedly. I mean I'm sure there's a little bit of overlap there but — and he was talking about his — I think Schoenberg was talking about his fourth string quartet and he said he would go out for his morning walks and write twenty measures and then come back and spend the rest of the afternoon transcribing what he just wrote. And if you listen to the first movement of that string quartet it is so complex. It's like I go out and try to write a blues in my head and I can't do that. And he's writing four parts. It's extraordinary.

MR: That's stunning. There's a — not to get too much into the weeds but in "Widow's Walk" there is a chord that occurs I think in measure seven. And am I correct that basically the song is in D minor?

RM: Um hum.

MR: So there's the chord in measure seven [scats] and it goes up and lands on an F sharp.

RM: Right.

MR: I love that. And it's so arresting but not unpleasant.

RM: Yes. To me that's — I don't want to say the whole beauty of the song, but that one note is the note that kind of sets up the whole turnaround and it is really, it's like if you're looking at a painting of yellows and oranges there's that one little dot of purple in it that really stands out. And it's because it's the two chord. So it would be — so we're in D minor, it's E half diminished but with a natural nine, with the F sharp, which really sets up the flat thirteen over the A seven. Because without that then you have those two F naturals in a row over the two and then the five. So I love that movement of natural nine on the half diminished chord, which like you just said not to get too much into the weeds but that comes from the melodic minor scale. It's the sixth degree so it's half diminished with a natural nine as opposed to thinking about it as a Locrian chord which gives you the flat nine over the half diminished, which is a sound I never really liked in that situation.

MR: Did you at the moment think that about what you were playing at the piano or did you play it and then put those terms to it?

RM: I think they kind of happened simultaneously because I was thinking, like I said, the form kind of just dictated itself so it just felt like it was just going to be a sixteen measure song. So nothing like A-A-B-A, nothing with a bridge. I was just thinking about a just kind of a smaller repeating form. So I knew at that point I needed the turnaround to get back to the one chord and I know since I'm in minor I always usually treat the two chord with that sharp — with the natural nine. So it kind of just came out because that's kind of what my ear was pre-hearing. But intellectually that's something that I kind of had thought about so when I get to that point in most songs that's the kind of a note I'll try to fit in in the voicing somewhere. If that makes sense.

MR: Yes and it worked. There's a little review here from one of those jazz collection books about CDs and the reviewer was talking about this recording, the whole record, and he said "The long Rollinish cadenza on 'My Foolish Heart,' the compelling circles cast through 'Widow's Walk,' the neo-blues shapes of 'Steppin' Out' — there's not a bad passage on the disc."

RM: Wow. That's a nice one. I'll take it.

MR: Yeah. You'll take that. You had "compelling circles." Before we get off this composing topic, I've seen that you've written some larger works, a concerto. Have you had that experience where you work — we get used to, in the jazz world, you know a song can be seven minutes long because it includes improvisation by the band members. I'm wondering, 'cause this has happened to me, like I labor on something that's more of a classical nature and I like it and then I play it back and I go wow, okay I have forty seconds so far. It's a different bag for sure.

RM: It really is. Two minutes worth of music — I was reading an article, an interview of Vince Mendoza and he was talking about two or three minutes of music and how much that actually is, without any improvising. That's a lot of music to compose to fit — yeah 'cause we're so used to just having something, you know just a little blues head and then the solos could take up most of the space. But yeah, it's a challenge obviously. And I'm a huge fan of Mahler. So his time scale is huge. You know half an hour movements are nothing for him. Sometimes they're longer than that. And then you have hour long, hour twenty minute symphonies. So I've studied a lot of his scores. So my orchestral writing is nothing I've really studied with anybody on, it was more about looking at scores, doing a lot of listening and actually reading biographies and autobiographies of composers. So when they talk about their process that was to me really informative.

MR: You and Alan Broadbent. He is a Mahler aficionado I would say.

RM: Oh really. Wow.

MR: Do you consider your — I'll just use the word "classical" or "orchestral." Is it — what's the term, "through" composed? Which I believe means not necessarily themes developed and returned to.

RM: Yes. There might be a little bit of that — themes — well definitely themes developed. But if I return to something I try not to ever return to it verbatim. There's a phrase used when people — I think it was Schoenberg talking about Brahms, about constant variation. So you're really thinking about kind of planting a seed and it growing and never changing. It always turns into something different but you can backtrack and see how it relates to the first little seed that was planted. The Ninth Symphony of Mahler, the first movement, it's extraordinary. It's one of my favorites. One thing, because harmonically it's kind of the last one, it's the bridge between all the romantic, late romantic classical music and symphonies, and it turns into Schoenberg and Webern and Berg. That's kind of the one movement that almost breaks tonality. And within the first, I think it's six measures there were five or six different little things that happened and those things continue for the next thirty minutes but in different registers, different instruments, different modes. And it's almost like this organism that is breeding for a half an hour and constantly changing. And it's extraordinary. So when I compose I try to think like that, where there are these little elements that are parts of the fabric but are kind of moving and taking on different roles and just developing themselves, kind of letting them be what they need to be, or want to be.

MR: Nice description. I think you just used the term "breaking with tonality." I hope I'm quoting you correctly. And it makes me think about — I was looking at some of your transcribed solos on line. First of all have you looked at your transcribed solos on line?

RM: Solos that I have done of other people?

MR: Yeah. And other people have transcribed them.

RM: Oh you mean some people have transcribed my playing?

MR: Correct.

RM: Oh yeah because there are some transcriptions that I did of other players that are out there as well. Yes actually, there's a book that was out a while ago and the person who did the transcriptions, he's actually a fine saxophonist from Michigan, John Wojciehowski. He actually sent me, I think there are like ten solos in this book, to edit them, to make sure that they were correct.

MR: How do you know they're correct?

RM: Well I can kind of tell just by reading through them and if I wasn't sure I would listen to the recording.

MR: Okay.

RM: And check it against.

MR: The reason I said that so quickly is because —

RM: No, it's okay.

MR: I was looking at them and there's things in there in many of your solos that from a harmonic standpoint are breaking the tonality. I'm going to use that term because you used it. For instance the chord symbol is A minor and you're playing a C sharp. So I'm trying to figure out, I don't have a question here but this idea of playing outside the change has fascinated me. It's something I have trouble doing myself. Is, in your head is there a theory behind that or — I did notice that a lot of times when you're playing outside the change it's part of a sequence you're doing. You've got a phrase and you're going to repeat it but you're going to move up or down even though let's say the chord may not go with that. I don't know what you can do with that comment, but —

RM: Yeah. Well I'm not sure if — you talked about having notes for what we're going to talk about — I have a book that came out last — in January. If that's going to be part of what we're going to talk about.

MR: Yeah I'd like to get to that *365 Days*.

RM: So in that book — so we could talk about the structure of the book later but in the beginning of that book I talk about this practice routine that I kind of learned and developed as a result of studying with a great saxophone player named Gary Campbell who was teaching at the University of Miami when I was there some years ago, and who also went to Indiana University when Michael Brecker was there so they used to practice together. And Michael always credits Gary as being a big influence on his practicing. So this is all a preface to answering your question. Part of this practice method is a thing called the "Intervallic Families" and it comes from dividing up the octave. So there's half steps, whole steps, minor thirds, major thirds, fourths, tritones, and fifths. And after fifths any interval bigger than that could be — what's the word — reverted back to one of the other intervals. So say for example a minor sixth, from C to A flat is just an inversion of a major third, from A flat to C. And in a major sixth, from C to A is just an inversion of a minor third. So basically you have half steps, whole steps, minor thirds, major thirds, fourths and fifths. So if you memorize those groups then you start seeing how you can get from any note in any key over any chord. So say for example you say A minor and then you say C sharp. So if you think about A minor moving up in major thirds, so that gives you A minor, C sharp minor, and F minor. So we're thinking about A is the root, and moving up in major thirds. Right? So A minor, C sharp minor, F minor. So that C sharp, although against an A chord, it's the major third, but it's the root of C sharp minor. So if you play — something goes from C sharp minor down to A minor, or you can go up, C sharp minor, F minor to A minor, the parallel nature of what you're playing justifies that wrong sound.

MR: Justifies it.

RM: Or yeah. I call it justifying it or neutralizing it.

MR: In your head, let's see, I'm trying to phrase this, what is the — where does the part come in, does it sound good? After all that pausing that was a heck of an adjective.

RM: Well two things. You asked the question earlier about a system and structures and patterns. That's the dangerous thing about practicing this way is you don't want to sound too mechanical and sound like you're playing too many patterns. So you have to practice patterns to not be afraid of that C sharp over A minor because you know how to get back to where you need to be. And then slowly but surely when you practice this way it just becomes a natural way of hearing music as opposed to — so to me you want to be able to kind of really combine the brain and the heart and the ears. So the brain comes in when you're studying the theory and practicing all the patterns. And then the ears come is like when I hear an A minor on the piano I hear that C sharp now as part of the — it's a totally acceptable note to use. It's not anything to be afraid of because I know how to relate it back to the A minor. I lost your voice.

MR: Okay. The actual pitch of the C sharp, in other words if you're playing at the high end of your sax or in the middle, is that part of your decision to play it? Where it's actually coming out in relationship to the piano chords or —

RM: No, not really. Maybe because of where I was before in terms of the line, but not in relationship to like the range of the piano. But I don't know what this is going to sound like but just so quickly now if you're thinking A minor [plays chord on sax] Right? So when I hear that and am thinking about the three minor chords that are related by major thirds. So you have [plays saxophone]. So if we're hearing something with this as the root [plays one note] we get that in our ears, if the bass is playing it or the piano or whatever, you can go [plays]. So there I started immediately at a C sharp minor, went up to F minor, back to C sharp and then back to A. So it depends if you have sixteen measures of A minor or you have two measures, about how much time you have to get to where you want to go. [Plays]

MR: Is that technique under your fingers now?

RM: Yes.

MR: Okay.

RM: It's also like I said, it's a combination of it being between in my fingers and in my ears. And hearing that it's not anything that all of a sudden like afraid of playing — that's kind of one of the first notes I'll go for sometimes. And a good way to practice that is to just play an A minor on the piano and play that wrong note and listen to where it wants to go. Right? So I don't have a keyboard here with me but if we're going [plays sax] we're getting that in our ears, and somebody goes [plays one note].

MR: You know it just occurred to me it's almost the opposite of — if you're playing an A blues there's a C sharp in the chord but the C natural is like the blue note, which you'd go to that constantly. And so you're kind of flipping harmonically — you've got the major against the minor.

RM: As opposed to the minor against the major. Yeah. That's part of it. Except see when I'm playing the blues and we play the blue note I'm not really thinking that, well sometimes I am but I'm normally not thinking about that as a group of triads in relationship to A, but just the note that wants to go up a half step.

MR: Okay.

RM: And the same thing even when you're playing C sharp over A minor you can just think about it as [plays] so that's just going up the A minor triad [plays] but at that point I'm not playing a C sharp minor triad or anything it's just where that C sharp wants to come back down to the minor third.

MR: Okay.

RM: But you could extend it [plays]. So that C sharp represents C sharp minor. But it also could just represent a note that wants to go a half step down to the minor third. So as a result of practicing really simple things but in all those different relationships, so minor triads and half steps [plays]. I'm only just doing a little portion of it but so that's minor triad kind of going up and down in half steps, then whole steps [plays]. And minor triads and minor thirds [plays]. And then minor triads and major thirds [plays].

MR: When you practice that kind of thing do you start in different places on your horn?

RM: Yeah. I do it always from the bottom note, the lowest note possible, up to as high as I can play. So I try to cover the whole range.

MR: I see.

RM: So depending on — and that's a minor triad in root position, right? So then you do the same thing with a minor triad in second inversion. Right? So that's a completely different shape. And then when you take that through the routine it has different ramifications.

MR: Thank you for all this.

RM: No, of course. No my pleasure. I mean it's fun to talk about.

MR: It's interesting because over the years as I've started to — you know we started interviewing fellas that were in their 80s and 90s and that was thirty years ago. Then I started asking the question of mid-generation players, "Is there any such thing in improvising as a mistake?" And mostly you get the quick response, like "No! No mistakes!" And I like to say well I have sure found them. But in — your description is very helpful and I also think there's part of it that is the way you deliver it with bold tone and unapologetically, that that has a lot to do with it.

RM: Of course. Yeah. If anything I still sometimes make mistakes rhythmically because I haven't spent as much time on that as I have on harmony and melody and you know for years I've been telling myself I'm going to learn to play the drums and I still haven't. Because Liebman and Brecker and Lovano, they all play really great drums and that has to help. So there's still some times where I'll kind of doubt my rhythmic placement and just that little millisecond of hesitation ruined it for me. So it's a mistake just because I'm not completely confident or there is — like I said — that little thing of hesitation.

MR: Okay. Well for a working musician these days it's obviously important to be versatile and when I — it was interesting last week that I was re-listening to — oh by the way the title "Widow's Walk" when did that come into the creation of that work?

RM: I actually don't remember. You know sometimes, I don't know if it's the same for you, actually finding the title for the song is harder than writing the song.

MR: Indeed.

RM: And there are some times where I'll have a title and that makes writing the song easier because you automatically have either a mood or an emotion that is associated with that title. But that's not the case with "Widow's Walk" but the title I don't remember hearing when or how I heard it but to me it was like perfect for that mood of that song. And for those people who don't know what a widow's walk is, it's the perch around the top of a light house where the women would go out to see if the ships were coming back, and a lot of times unfortunately they would come back but without their husbands or their boyfriends. Yeah. So that was just a haunting image to me.

MR: It all works. Where I was going was that when I listen to it and, you know how YouTube is, you're watching something and then over on the right hand side you might want to watch this. There was this video of you playing with Miles and an extended solo, and you were like really giving it all you had and you're surrounded by electronic instruments, and the contrast between those two pieces of music was very telling. I wondered when you were playing with Miles in that kind of situation did you ever get into a situation where you're playing and playing and in your head you're thinking okay Miles, I'm done now? Like can we move on?

RM: Maybe. Yeah. Because we all had usually one solo of the night that was our main feature. I took other solos throughout the night with him but there's that one, it's on "Human Nature," the Michael Jackson song. And it was just concert A minor, so B minor — are you a tenor player? I didn't ask earlier.

MR: Mostly alto and soprano.

RM: So it was an A minor concert, so B minor for us, and you know I think that I mean he was so aware of what was going on that he sometimes probably let me go past that point where I thought I was finished just to force me to find something else. And I'll tell you,

that feeling was better than feeling like I had more to go and then have him cut me off, which sometimes, occasionally that happened where I felt like I was not really finished but you know you're kind of playing, yeah because of course you don't tell him when you're finished, he's going to come and tell you. So you're kind of playing and you get to a certain point in your solo where you know it's about that time where it might be close to the end so kind of playing but looking over your shoulder to see where he was.

MR: You mean physically where he was?

RM: Yeah, because he would usually kind of come over and when he was close to you he would kind of play something that would cue the band and that was it.

MR: Okay.

RM: So yeah there were —

MR: Did you have rehearsals for that, was it six or seven weeks that you played with them — at least from what I read — and were there rehearsals before that? Because he's not calling tunes like "Green Dolphin Street."

RM: No there wasn't. And I can tell you quickly the story of how I got the gig is I was living in New Orleans at the time and my friend from high school and college, his name is Matt Pearson who is a producer now, he was working as an intern at Blue Note. And he said, "Put together a demo tape because I can get it to Bruce Lundvall who is the president of Blue Note, and we might be able to do a record together. So I sent a tape and he played it for Bruce and Bruce said yeah, let's do the record with him. But Matt also sent that same tape to Tommy LiPuma who was producing "Amandla" at the time. And some weeks later I was still living in New Orleans and I got a call from Tommy saying, "Rick, I just heard the tape and I played it for Miles over the phone and Miles told me to call you and tell you you have a job."

MR: Wow.

RM: So yeah, that was like extraordinary of course, one of the most extraordinary moments of my life just to have that happen. And of course the tape was good and I had to be able to deliver, but it was also a case of who you know. Because if it wasn't for Matt being in New York at that time and knowing that Miles was in the studio and like all the coincidences that had to happen for that to happen was pretty amazing. So the original thing was, it was two saxophones. It was me with Kenny Garrett. And I had seen that band and that show a couple of times. So at that point in Miles' career it was kind of like the same structure every night. There wasn't too many variations. So I kind of knew what the show was about. So I flew to New York and, yeah, Tommy said Miles wants to meet me. So of course I was scared shitless. It's like, and I have no memory of getting in an airplane, of flying to New York, I don't remember how I got in the city, like it's really strange. I don't remember any of that. I just remember ending up at the Essex House, the

Marriott on Central Park South, which is where Miles was living, and got to his door and it said "Please take off your shoes." So I was standing there with my horn and my shoes for about 15 minutes, and I finally got the courage to knock on the door. And he opened the door with a smile on his face and he brought me in and I was totally at ease. It was really, really an extraordinary moment. Because I wasn't sure if he was going to ask me to play or what it was going to be like. And all he did was he said sit down, and he went on his desk, or this big dining room table, and was searching through a bunch of tapes and papers, and he just gave me a cassette and he said, "I'll see you on stage."

MR: Wow.

RM: So I transcribed a couple of the melodies that I had heard already just so I was just ready to do that. But I didn't really have to do that much playing of the melodies by myself because Kenny was there. And that was — this is also an amazing story. We were in Stockholm, that was the first gig. And after that gig Miles collapsed backstage. He fainted. So yeah, he was not in the best of health obviously. So the next day we were getting on the bus and he comes to me and says, "It's too much energy to have another person on stage" because that means he has to figure out where to give somebody else an extra solo and kind of change — so he said, "I'll call you when Kenny leaves." So I played one gig and I flew back to New York like two days later. And I was like what just happened? Did I suck? Did he not like — you know all the questions. And I think it was about a month later they were getting ready to do their next leg of the tour which was six weeks. And he called me and said, "Kenny just left, we need you." And the first gig I played was in Stockholm. So I started where I left off and from that point I did the six weeks without Kenny. And the show was the same and so no rehearsal, we just went out there and the band was exactly the same so I was just there but by myself, not with Kenny, and just playing little melodies and short little things that I needed to do and yeah, no rehearsals. And sound checks Miles was never there. We just went and checked the sound without him.

MR: You can't make this kind of thing up, can you?

RM: I know. It's extraordinary.

MR: Was it the loudest you'd ever played? The loudest group you'd ever played in? Or did you have experience before that in funk bands or that type.

RM: Yeah, because when I was living in New Orleans I played in some blues bands on Bourbon Street that were pretty loud. You know because we also weren't playing in clubs, they were all pretty big venues. So it was loud but never so loud because — you know I actually played in big bands that were louder because you had brass sections right behind you. So it really wasn't that bad because we were spread out on the stage.

MR: Yeah. Wow thanks for sharing that.

RM: No, my pleasure.

MR: What prompted you to relocate to Paris?

RM: Well I was living in New York — well so I lived, at this point I was in New Orleans and then when the Blue Note thing happened and Miles happened it was 1989 or so, and I always wanted to move to New York. So I moved to New York around '89 and was there for about ten years. And at that point you know in New York there still is not — you know you're doing these little gigs but you're not making a lot of money and since I was kind of new on the scene I got calls to come over to Europe to do jazz festivals, and that's where the majority of American jazz musicians make decent money is by coming over to Europe and playing you know, unless you're really famous and you're able to tour around the country with your own band, but that takes a while to happen. So it really didn't happen for me. I was coming over to Europe and making more of a name for myself that way. And I always loved Paris. And I thought this would be a cool place to live because just the city itself, and I realized it's kind of the hub of Europe so it makes getting to Germany, to Austria, to Belgium, to Amsterdam, to London on a train really easy. So of course because what we do there is a lot of traveling involved, but the trains are always much cooler than the airports. So I kind of planted that seed and I had some friends who were living in Paris, but I never really did anything proactive about finding my way over here, just kind of thinking it would be a cool thing to do. And it was in 2000 — well before that I mean — I think around 2001 I got asked to join a French band call the Moutin Reunion Quartet. It's twin brothers, and the bass player, Francois, lived in New York. His brother Louis lives in Paris, and I became friends with Francois. And they had a working band and their saxophone player left. So Francois asked me if I wanted to join the band. So that means I was coming over to France even more. I was living in an illegal sublet on the upper West Side and we got caught so I was going to have to find another place to live in New York, which is always very traumatic and not cheap. And a relationship I was in with a girl had ended like a couple of months before that, and so there was three things. And then a friend of mine in Paris who knew I was talking about moving here, he actually called me and said, "Rick, I'm leaving, if you want you could have my apartment."

MR: The planets aligned.

RM: Yeah. So the universe gave me like four major signs, and I said if I don't do this something bad is going to happen. And I said, and if I don't do it I also am going to regret not taking the chance. So yeah, and I said if I didn't like it I could always move back.

MR: What did mom and dad think?

RM: You know actually I was actually really nervous about telling them, and I remember because I grew up in Detroit, we were all from Detroit, but at that point my parents had

moved to Nevada. They live near Las Vegas in Henderson. And I remember finally getting the courage up to talk to them on the way to the airport. They were driving me home after Christmas and I was flying back to New York and I said, "I just got a chance to move to Paris, what do you think?" And they were both really happy. My father was like, "That would be an amazing experience for you." So other than making it more difficult for me to get home to see them because obviously travel from Paris to Las Vegas is like — it's not easy. But yeah they were supportive. And once I got here, and it wasn't like I was moving to Paris without knowing anybody. So I had a reputation and I had some friends here so it was relatively kind of easy, and also having a place to live that I knew about.

MR: I want to read, this is connected to jazz in Europe. And it had an interview with Pierre Boussaguet and —

RM: Um hum.

MR: He said this about American jazz. He says — he was talking about playing with visiting jazz musicians. "It's an honor because jazz to me has always been, historically speaking, a pure American art form that's so powerful, so joyful that it spread throughout the world." And another quote from the pianist Rossano Sportiello from Italy, who now lives here. He said, "The most beautiful compliment that we could tell each other was, 'Tonight you sounded like an American'." So my question is nowadays do jazz musicians in France still aspire to sound like Americans or have they developed their own personality?

RM: I think it's more the latter than the former. You know I don't know exactly like, the time period-wise, like when the university, the conservatory system started here with jazz departments, like I think maybe earlier in the States than it has over here. But like the main conservatory here in Paris, there are a lot of great young musicians and they're definitely into, I don't want to say avante garde, because it's not just that, but it's more about writing their own original music that has kind of like an ECM kind of European quality. They're not really playing bebop although teachers are teaching that as something you have to have but that's not the end, it's just kind of a means to an end. So I would say yes, it's definitely less about emulation and sounding American except they're obviously influenced by, you know a lot of the young piano players I think as opposed to maybe sounding like Wynton Kelly, they're into Brad Mehldau. Right? Which I guess that's kind of a natural generational thing, although we're also telling these young guys before you go to Brad you have to check out Wynton, because Brad checked out Wynton. You know so it's like the whole lineage part of developing. But definitely the younger generation, they're more into the odd meter kind of thing, blending Afro — or ethnic kind of world music stuff, Steve Coleman kind of influence, Robert

Glasper. You know so there's more of that going on. So maybe influence by American musicians but a different generation of them.

MR: If you went to a jam session in Paris is it old fashioned to say, "All right, let's do a blues in B flat"?

RM: No but that's the other part of it. The older I get, the harder it is for me to leave the house. If I'm home I'd rather just stay home and practice or compose, so I'm not out as much. But if I'm already out and it's close to the time when the sessions are going to start, the jam sessions are still pretty conservative though, to answer your question. And it depends on the night, it depends who's there, the level could be, there could be a couple of great players and a couple of less experienced players, so kind of the common ground is still let's play "Stella" or let's play a standard. So when you go out to a jam session it's not really the kind of experimental stuff I was talking about earlier. But it's more if you're going to go hear a young French group play their music it's going to be more originals and something a little less beboppy for lack of a better term.

MR: I don't know if you can address this question, depending on how long you've been over there, but do you think it's as challenging for your students to find a way to make a living in this music as it has become in the States?

RM: I'm just speculating on how difficult it is in the States because I haven't been there in over — but I imagine it's hard. There's more support from governments and from little cultural centers all around France and I assume the same in Germany. Of course it's different after Covid but there are more places to play and more respect for artists in Europe in general. That's also one of the things that led me to wanting to move here. So for young musicians I imagine that there are more resources in terms of getting funding for little projects, and like I said, little cultural centers where you can play and put on concerts. And because everything is so close and each scene is different, so if you're in France you can go to Germany on the train in three hours and be part of a completely different scene as opposed to, you know say driving from New York to Philly you're still part of the East Coast scene so there's going to be kind of the same amount of exposure as opposed to going to a completely different country. And of course just our generation, you know because of the, all the streaming stuff now, and the lack of record labels, it's something that we have to deal with because it's not part of our wheelhouse. But for them, having an Instagram account and putting your records and doing your shit in there, that's just like, that's — they don't know what they're missing so that's just what they do.

MR: They don't know what they're missing. Yeah, we could say oh boy, back in our day, you know we had — but even back then people, when you had a record label mostly they complained about it.

RM: Yeah of course. Yeah, sure. They didn't do enough. But at least there were record labels you know but then you know I talked to Dave Liebman and he says, "Yeah, you missed the golden age when there were five or six clubs in New York where the people were playing for six nights a week. Probably more than a — and a circuit around the States where you can get in and do that. I mean I only played with my own band in New York for six nights I think one time, the old Sweet Basil's. But I never had that experience of going out and playing my own music for 40 weeks a year, which is extraordinary. Now if I do three nights in a row it's rare, and I feel the difference after the first night. My playing is completely different because there's a reference from the night before. So it's frustrating. And even now I have a steady Monday night gig in Paris, we've been doing it for the last five years. And that's a luxury to have, but even once a week is definitely not enough. It takes me a set just to kind of feel loose and then the gig is over. So, you know, the good old days.

MR: This is a question you can pass on if you'd like. As an American living abroad, do you observe the political and social scene in the United States, and how does it strike you?

RM: Everybody that I've talked to over here is stunned by the stupidity of half of the American public. They can't understand how this happened a second time. But everybody is also afraid because a lot of countries here are swinging to the right. Countries are getting more nationalistic because of immigrants and Covid and all the shit that's happened. So it's scary. Brexit, LePen almost winning here in France. I don't remember the name, the prime minister in Italy, but the woman — Sweden has gone a little further to the right, so it's kind of happening everywhere but none of them can compare to Trump in terms of lack of intelligence and an evil agenda and the shit he's gotten away with and so I don't know if that answers your question.

MR: It does and it's striking that half the country feels like you do and myself and so forth, and not to make a political agenda out of this interview but I was curious, from you know the other side of the ocean what the feeling is.

RM: Yeah everybody is shocked and frankly they're frightened by what's going to happen economically because of the tariffs and all this stuff he's talking about doing, and also what's doing to happen to Ukraine and the war in Israel. I mean so yeah, everybody's on heightened alert I would say, and depressed.

MR: Okay.

RM: Yeah where do we go from here.

MR: I'm looking — here's where we're going. I'll sort of wrap up with — on both sides of me in my office here I have a list of sort of a discography of you. And it has all your solo, your records under your own name and so I'm going to pick two things that you did and

see if you have a memory or comment about them. And I'll start with Ellis Marsalis, "A Night at Snug Harbor." What do you remember about that date?

RM: Well Snug Harbor is one of the only clubs — few clubs at that time that was doing modern jazz, so that's where I played almost all the time. Other than that I was doing weddings and club dates and stuff like that. I remember it being a little chaotic because there was a cast of characters and not everybody played on every song so there was a lot of kind of moving around. There wasn't that much planned in advance other than a possibility of a couple of different songs, so a little bit chaotic. But knowing everybody in the club and all the musicians, and the vibe was cool so we'll just kind of hang out until it's time to play. You know and at that point I was still a little unsure of myself musically so, maybe a little intimidated by the older generation like am I ready to play with these guys, am I good enough. So there's a little bit of that self-doubt. But mainly being on stage with friends, a pleasant experience, yeah.

MR: Okay. And Ellis was an interesting guy.

RM: Ellis was very cool. You know once again I was just this young little white guy in New Orleans not knowing that many people so I was kind of in awe of him and the same thing with Miles. I really didn't want to talk too much because I didn't want to say anything stupid so — but he was a sweetheart so it was just mainly just being respectful and — yeah.

MR: Okay how about — would you like to share something about I don't know if this is your latest record, "Sacred Hearts."

RM: Yeah.

MR: All original material?

RM: All original material, yeah. So the nucleus, the quartet on that record is the quartet that I work with here in Paris, and actually the drummer is one of my oldest friends from New Orleans named Jeff Boudreaux, who was in Paris before I was, also the bass player named Peter Giron is from New York in the Bronx. So three ex-pats and a French pianist, and we had been working together for the last five, six, seven years. So going in there and having my band and the music that we had been playing made it relatively stress-free. Because usually going into a recording studio can be kind of intimidating. But we just went in there and played our music and that's the nucleus of the record. And I knew that after I had that stuff recorded my plan was to then overdub percussion and guitars and some keyboards and singing and so it's kind of like we did the first round — I don't want to say adding all the details made it go from color to black & white — I mean from black & white to color, because it wasn't in black & white to begin with, but I feel like I went in there afterwards and then orchestrated it. And the tracks were done for a while and then the rest of the process took even longer so I think from the beginning to the end, the

whole record took almost four years, even though the majority of it was recorded in four days. The finishing of it and the mixing and mastering and orchestrating and bringing people in to do the overdubbing and all that was done in stages.

MR: Did you have — well it could be a producer but I'm thinking of an outside ear to you know contribute that sound? Because sometimes it's hard to be objective about your own work.

RM: Absolutely it is. Not somebody who was in the studio working with me. I kind of had a general — because the record I made before that was kind of the same but the basic tracks were more world music influenced. This was more — I hate to compare it — it's kind of like a Pat Metheny with saxophone sound, more kind of American, not as ethnic. So I had that first experience as an experience to help me, but then I would take certain tracks and then play it for the guys in the band or just snippets and say what does this sound like, what did you think? So that's the only sounding board. I didn't really have a producer other than me, and then when we finally got to the mix the engineer was really good so he had some insights into how things should just be panned and of course balanced and then he did have some suggestions for a couple of the arrangements, like maybe there are too many vocals at this point so we could thin them out here. So yeah. Mainly just kind of my own vision of what I wanted it to be.

MR: You know when you said "overdub" I can't believe that — I'm going back to it, the "Widow's Walk," people have to listen to this because one thing that I remember, especially the first time I heard it was you were playing the melody on the tenor and then the soprano entered. Am I correct? I'm assuming that was you as well. It sounded like then there was an intertwining of two horns and then it ended up in unison.

RM: Yeah it is me. I'm trying to think — yeah the second voice is soprano I'm pretty sure. I don't think I did it with two tenors. But yeah on that first record there's another one I did, I did the melody just with three horns. And it's kind of — I've had fun doing that over the years. So "Sacred Hearts," it didn't start out originally with it being this kind of tribute album but then it did as the material kind of fell into place. So each song is kind of dedicated to somebody that I lost. Because between the recording of "Sacred Hearts" and the one I did before that which is called "Bohemia" it was like nine or ten years since I did a record under my own name. So "Sacred Hearts" has dedications to all the people that I had lost in those ten years. But it's not really a sad record, it's more celebrating them you know. So the one I wrote for Michael Brecker is called "Country Mike." And at the end there's a vamp that goes on for a while and there were nine different tracks of me improvising. And that was super fun to put together. And then the orchestrating of it, the melody itself has three or four sopranos playing with the piano and — if you haven't heard that one I think you would enjoy it, and you can go on YouTube and find that one.

MR: I'll check it out. No wonder it took four years.

RM: But I said even on that it's still — it took nine of me to make one Michael Brecker and not even then was I successful.

MR: Well this has been a fascinating conversation and I want to thank you for your time. And I hope that people after watching it go check out your music. And thank you.

RM: My pleasure. You know there's certain people you kind of just start talking to and it just feels natural so I really appreciate you. Thank you for inviting me and I'm glad to be part of the lineage of the show.

MR: All right. I'm going to end this and we'll just say good-bye.

RM: Okay. Thanks, Monk.

MR: Yeah. Okay we are — oops, are you still there?

RM: I'm still here.

MR: Okay. We stopped recording. They keep updating Zoom and the little things you're used to doing are like oh no they've changed. I have a theory about things like this, in all walks of life, things keep getting improved until they don't work anymore.

RM: That's very astute and it's borne out in a lot of different areas.

MR: All right. So you can check, you're able to check obviously your bank statements and let me know that this thing arrives, I hope soon. And —

RM: Yeah if I don't see it in a couple of weeks then I'll just check in with you.

MR: Oh yeah. I'm pretty sure it'll show up before that. If you ever get back in the States and you're going through Central New York you let us know.

RM: Absolutely. It'd be nice to meet in person for sure.

MR: Absolutely.

RM: So have a great Thanksgiving and Christmas and all that stuff and hopefully we'll cross paths again at some point.

MR: Okay.

RM: All right thanks Buddy. Take care.

MR: Thank you, bye.